

The Agile Mindset

Agile is not a methodology. It's not Scrum, sprints, or stand-ups. It's a set of values.

The Agile Manifesto

In 2001, seventeen software developers published four value statements:

Individuals and interactions over processes and tools
Working software over comprehensive documentation
Customer collaboration over contract negotiation
Responding to change over following a plan

The items on the right have value. But the items on the left have *more* value.

What This Means

Individuals and interactions over processes and tools

Processes and tools help, but they don't replace people talking to each other. A team with great communication and mediocre tools will outperform a team with great tools and poor communication.

Working software over comprehensive documentation

Documentation has its place, but the primary measure of progress is software that actually works. A 100-page spec means nothing if the software doesn't run.

Customer collaboration over contract negotiation

Instead of hiding behind contracts and requirements documents, work *with* the customer throughout. They're not adversaries — they're partners in solving the problem.

Responding to change over following a plan

Plans are useful, but they're guesses about the future. When reality differs from the plan, adapt. Don't cling to a plan that no longer makes sense.

The Twelve Principles

Behind the manifesto are twelve principles. A few key ones:

- Deliver working software frequently
- Welcome changing requirements, even late in development
- Build projects around motivated individuals and trust them
- The best architectures and designs emerge from self-organizing teams
- Working software is the primary measure of progress
- Sustainable pace — the team should be able to maintain this indefinitely

Agile as Foundation

These values inform everything in this guide. When we discuss practices like TDD or pair programming, they exist because they embody these values — fast feedback, collaboration, working software, adaptation.

References

- The Agile Manifesto — The original source, including the twelve principles
- *The Art of Agile Development* by James Shore — The best book for understanding Agile in depth and in practice